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Janet Finch

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2001

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

UK Data Archive, University of Essex, Colchester. June 2017

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Professor Janet Finch

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

7 August 2001, 8 August 2001

1. Early childhood in a very female family

I was a classic post-War baby, yes! Yes, yes, yes! Born and brought up in Liverpool. My family, I think both sides had been in Liverpool for several generations.. My family was really a very female family, actually, and a very kind of happy, fairly large female family - not actually because my immediate family was large, because it wasn't. … I've just got one sister, and she's nearly eight years younger than me, so, really, in childhood, we didn't know each other very well. So my experience of being a child was more like being a single child, an only child., I think. (p.1)

My mother was also an only child. But her family was enormous. Her mother was the eldest of seven children. They all lived in relatively close proximity, and they had a family grocer's shop, actually, which they still had when I was a child. So my grandmother and one of her sisters, and one of her brothers, ran the shop, and we lived very close to that, and that was very much the centre of family gatherings on a regular basis. They did actually have a flat over the shop, though we never, we never lived there … until I was seven, we actually lived with my grandmother, who lived almost next door to the shop. So it was very much around this … so my maternal family's grocer's shop, which, itself, was the centre of family life, and so uncles, aunts and cousins were very important to me in my childhood. (p.1)

2. Family photograph as a touchstone for memory

One of my earliest memories is captured, forever, in a photograph which I used as the front cover of the book, *Family Obligations and Social Change*, which is a four-generation family picture, with me as a three-year old, and my mother and my grandmother and my great-grandmother, taken as a rather formal picture, in the flat above

this grocer's shop. It was taken, I'm sure it must have been taken because I was the first great-grandchild born to my great-grandmother. And I believe it was she who had the idea that you'd have four generations of women on this photograph. But it is a beautiful photograph, and I can actually remember the photographer coming and seating us. I think he must have been a very good photographer, because it is a very lovely picture, with everybody looking very much their own character, if you like. And though it was posed, it doesn't look posed, in that sense. And that represents not only my earliest, one of my earliest personal memories, but also, I think, very much a touchstone both for my own experiences of family life, and material which, subsequently, has been very important in driving my research programme. (p.2)

3. Living with a dominant grandmother

She was terrific! And she was a very dominant figure in my childhood, and my sister's, actually. She, as I say, she took an active part in running this grocery shop. She also lived very near to it, and we lived in her house when I was a small child…

She…she enjoyed … I've caught from her the enjoyment of meeting a wide range of people, of doing new things. She loved doing new things, really, until she was very old. And was very, I think, kind of flexible, more so than a number of people of her generation. I met the first people of Caribbean origin that I'd ever met, through her, because her next door neighbours were a white woman married to somebody who'd been born in Jamaica, I think, actually, because Liverpool, of course, has had a multi-racial community for a very, very long time, it's no big deal, in a way, in Liverpool. But she had these lovely next door neighbours who we all adored and, you know, got on well with them and so on. And so, you know, things like that she was very, very open about.
(pp. 2-3)

4. Men in the family and inheritance

Well, they were around. All three of them, who were, in fact, my great-uncles, of course, … certainly figured in my childhood… Two of them had been in the First World War,

and one of them worked for the Civil Service as an Income Tax collector, and had been posted to Dublin, just before the War, and was left there, and he was actually in Dublin in 1918, for the uprisings and so on. So he had that experience. But I don't think he ever was sent into the War. The other two were, and they both sustained some sort of disability as a consequence…

The other one didn't have any apparent physical disabilities, but they always used to speak in hushed tones about how he had suffered shell shock, and he was more than a little bit more than eccentric, it must be said! (LAUGHS) But this was all taken as part of family life. And they were there, but in the context of family gatherings, it was all very domestic, so the men, including my father, would be there, at least for part of the time, and then they would go off to the pub, or to play bowls, or something like that, while the women stayed in the house. Or they would be, you know, put off in one corner and given a cup of tea, while the women really got on with the gossiping and that kind of thing. So they were never excluded, but it was clear that they were very much bit players! (LAUGHS).

One of the brothers [ran] the shop. And there was, when the shop was sold, there was a real conflict over inheritance, actually, which has become, subsequently, one of the things I've done research on, with the brother actually taking the vast majority of the profits of the sale, and my grandmother and her sister, who had equally been involved in the running of the shop, were really … probably didn't get their fair share. (pp.3-4)

5. Learning about class from a grandmother

My paternal grandmother, on the other hand, in her widowhood, we did see quite a lot of, and she also lived quite nearby. She was a much less warm, and a much less sympathetic character than my maternal grandmother, and I was always slightly afraid of her, I think. But, on the other hand, totally fascinated, because she was out of a certain kind of mould of women of her generation, I think, who were very interested in respectability, and in structures of respectability, and particularly in drawing the boundaries around respectability, if you like. And so I used to absolutely adore going out with her.

She played bowls, in a Ladies' Bowling Club, and I used to get taken along when she was looking after me, and, you know, they would play bowls, then they would make tea and so on. And I used to absolutely love it, because I would sit on the sidelines and hear them all gossiping and doing character assassination on … on people they knew, who I didn't have the slightest idea who these people were, but it was very fascinating for a young child to sit in and listen to all of this! So I would say that, probably the main influence that I had from her, was actually unintended, which was an introduction to the gradations of the social environment of … what you might call upper working-class/lower middle-class life in Liverpool, at that time. (p.5)

6. A working father's influence

He, I mean, he was relatively successful in what he did. He went off, you know, as a 15 or 16-year old, and went to work for a small company where, I think, he stayed for the whole of his life, and ended up as one of the directors. And the company was a grain merchants. They had premises on the Dock Road in Liverpool, right by the side of the Docks, and they imported, I think they did import as well, but they certainly exported grain. So he began as something very junior, and worked his way up through sales and so on. But it was a very small company, but, you know, I mean, he clearly was quite good at this job. And when I was in my childhood, he was, basically, Director of Operations, or something like that, for this company, and it was always a great treat, though slightly frightening, because of the environment, to go and visit him in the office, because he had offices in what was basically a storage mill for grain that was going to be exported. And so it was a very kind of exotic environment, with rather a dangerous feel to it, and … and then this sort of rather cosy little office where he spent his time..

I think that I found him much more difficult to get close to than I did with any of the women in my family, though I think that he was extremely attached to me…And so he was … very supportive, and very keen to support what I was doing, but, I think, slightly bemused at how to treat daughters, really. So although we lived in … what now seems to me to be a very small house, in a funny way, he was a kind of distant figure.

He didn't eat meals with us, except on a Sunday, when it was a family ritual. Now, that was probably my mother's doing, actually. And it may have been, now that I look back on it, it may have been something to do with the fact, with economy, you know, that he had the meat and two veg every night, and we probably didn't, you know? I mean, I never thought that at the time, but I do wonder, now, whether that might have been a part of it. But, certainly, it seemed to be a very comfortable existence for, you know, mother and two daughters to have their little world, and he was slightly - got looked after, and drawn in, from time to time, into this female world, but was slightly on the fringes of it. (pp.6-7)

7. Child of a working mother

She left school and went and did a secretarial training, and worked as what we would now call a PA, and, I think, was very good at it. Married my father in 1940, but they didn't live together until after the War was over. So she was married for six years before I was born, and did give up work, I think, at that stage, but went back to work quite soon after my sister was born.

I think she was working for the Managing Director at some stage, at the later stages. Stayed, more or less, in that job, until she was 60. So my childhood, and certainly my later childhood, was one in which I did have a role model of a mother who went out to work and looked after the family at the same time. (p.8)

8. Family and politics

Oh, Conservative. Oh, yes, we haven't talked about politics, have we. My father was a member of the local Conservative Club, but I don't whether that was a political or a social affair, if you like. I suspect it was social! The … atmosphere in which all my family operated was … natural support for the Conservative Party. And, of course, Liverpool, in their … the middle years of the 20th century, in their adult life, was really a city in which the Labour Party was really pretty radical, and, regular strikes on the Docks and this kind of thing, so that Labour Party politics, in Liverpool, in a family like mine, was associated

with that kind of thing, and not with the sort of Fabian … social welfare reform kind of stuff. So, in some ways it doesn't surprise me that they had a natural affinity with the Conservative Party. (p.10)

9. Education and parents' strategy

One thing that I'll say at the beginning, and come back to is, I think, all of my schooling, I was educated entirely in female-only establishments, which is probably quite unusual. My schooling began, not terribly successfully, at a small private, what you can only call a "Dame School", I think, in a big old house nearby, which was not terrifically successful, actually. But I did go there until I was seven. I don't know what I learned really, but I … (LAUGHS), but I then went to the local primary school. …I was always sitting in … two or three desks at the corner of the classroom, where all the people who had done best, sat. And I found that a really pretty uncomfortable experience for most of my primary schooling, because I was always being picked out as being clever, being able to do things, and you, therefore, get backlash from the other children! (LAUGHS)…

I sat the 11+ examination, which I passed, of course, and also this Scholarship Examination for Merchant Taylor's. And the primary school that I went to had almost no experience of this. They didn't get very many people into the Grammar School, and I don't think they'd ever sent anybody to Merchant Taylor's before. And it must have been because my mother had been there that, you know, that my family had some notion that this was a good idea…

They were both very clear, particularly my father, that a good education was what was needed. And the fact that they had daughters didn't make any difference to that, you know, it was still what was needed. And I think my father did have something close to a strategy, quite apart from the fact that, you know, he did, very explicitly, want his children to have opportunities that he would have liked to have himself, but didn't. He actually had a strategy for daughters. I can remember this quite vividly, because at some point in, much later in my life, I think when I was at university, and wondering what to do afterwards, … I remember having several conversations with him, in which he was very firm on the point that I must get a job, and ideally, I must get myself professionally

qualified. And the reason for that was that, even though I thought I was going to get married, which I did quite soon after leaving university, you would never know, in your mid-thirties, you might be left on your own, and you then needed something to be able to look after yourself, you know, some means of properly looking after yourself. And I remember saying to him, "Oh, Dad, don't be ridiculous!" But actually, that is precisely what did happen! Well, not precisely, but it was close enough to make me remember what he'd said. And so he did actually have, he had a strategy, he wanted his daughters to be independent. (pp.11-13)

10. Parents and feminism

They thought that women were quite capable to do anything they wanted, and why should you worry about it, sort of thing. I never felt, with either of them, that because I was a woman, my life was going to be restricted to certain sorts of activities, actually. I wouldn't call it explicitly Feminist. (p.13)

11. 11. Losing a Liverpool accent at Merchant Taylors' School

I loved the … the educational part of it. You know, I mean, that was where, you know, I got introduced to literature and art and music and so on, and very much responded to all that. Less so to the sciences…

I did, however, find the social aspects of it very much more difficult to cope with, and I think that did really quite influence me in a number of ways, eventually making me somewhat politically more radical than I might otherwise have been... the one thing which they did do, which I've always deeply resented, was take my Liverpool accent away. It was, it was the School's policy, if you … The small number of us who had got into the School, with a Liverpool accent, had to stay back for elocution lessons after school. And, you know, at the age of ten, when you know you're in an environment that you don't belong, you've got a huge incentive to go along with this. And so I lost my Liverpool accent, and I never got it back again. (p.14)

12. Choosing sociology for university

The School was very focused on getting its girls into the best universities, and that meant as many as possible into Oxford and Cambridge, quite apart from anything else, and this little group that I was in, were all destined to go to Oxford and Cambridge. And for reasons that I can't entirely explain, even now, that have got something to do with the Church Youth Group that I was involved in, and developing a kind of social conscience, and developing some sort of political interest as well, I decided I wanted to do sociology. Now, this was 1963, and there wasn't much sociology around then…

I think I had some notion of possibly wanting to go into social work, and thinking that it was relevant to that. But I don't know how I'd heard about sociology, certainly not from the School. And I remember getting really quite fixed on this. And, of course in those days, neither Oxford nor Cambridge offered sociology. So I decided, I wasn't going to go to Oxford or Cambridge, I was going to somewhere where I could do sociology. And this was deeply offensive to the School, and they tried, did their best to persuade me to do English at Oxford, and assured me that I was bound to get in and so on, but I wouldn't have any of it. And in the end, I had to go and be interviewed by the Head, who said to me that it was, you know, it was a very wayward thing to want to do, and she was really very displeased with me. But if I absolutely insisted, as she'd understood from other teachers, I was doing, then she did know that you could sociology at London University. And so that's what she would recommend.

But, under no circumstances, would the School give me a reference for the London School of Economics, because that was too Left-wing! (LAUGHS) And so she'd been doing some other investigations, and she had discovered that Bedford College, which was a very respectable institution, where they had sent other girls, which, of course, was a women's college at that stage, offered sociology. And so if I insisted on pursuing this, they would, in fact, give me a reference for Bedford College, if I so wished. And so that's where I ended up. (pp.17-18)

13. Sociology at Bedford College

I thoroughly enjoyed my education in sociology, as an undergraduate. And it was only afterwards that I realised that it was, probably even when I had it, rather out of date! But it was quite, it was quite policy oriented, actually. Well, it was a mixture, really, of a policy orientation and … quite theoretical stuff…

And then we did quite a lot of sort of community, family welfare type issues, criminology, and a good methodology training in quantitative methods… The person in charge of the Department at Bedford, when I was there, was Oliver McGregor, … whose interests in sociology, very much shaped the curriculum, I think. And actually, have really shaped my interests to quite a remarkable extent, when I think about it… His interests were very much in family and, family marriages, not so much kinship, actually – marriage, family, children - from a mixture of a sociological analysis and a social welfare perspective. And was, I think was really quite a central figure in developing a sociological approach to those issues, from that sort of perspective, in this country… It was quite radical. And he was quite influenced by Feminism, first wave Feminism… Late 19th century Feminism. So the way he taught about families had a very strong gender perspective in it. (pp.20-21)

14. Marriage to Geoffrey Spedding

Well, I didn't have a plan – I've never had much of a plan, actually! Truly! And I, I did actually feel, and I think I was probably right to feel that, that the one thing I knew was that I didn't want to stay in a university environment, or to continue to a further level of education. I felt as if I'd spent all my life being educated. And, in a way, I think had, because, you know, the school that I went to, … you know, we worked pretty hard. And at university, I did … really lots of good things, and my cultural interests expanded quite significantly, but I still did work pretty hard. So I, the one thing that I didn't want to do was to continue with post-graduate work, but I didn't really know what I did want to do. I knew that I was probably going to get married fairly soon after that..

I'd known him [her husband] for a very long time, he was in the same Youth Club in Liverpool, that I belonged to. We were part of the same kind of … social awareness being raised at the same time, so to speak. He went to university in Hull, but we kept in close contact while we were both at university. And so I didn't really know what I wanted to do. I did know that I needed to be somewhere near Cambridge, which was where he was going to be, and so I applied for, and got, a teaching post in a girls' secondary modern school, which was in Bishop's Stortford.

[I] quite enjoyed it. They were just beginning to teach 'O' level sociology, so I introduced 'O' level sociology at this school, and my pupils all did very well, and it was okay. It was a slightly eccentric sort of place…We'd settled into Cambridge, I'd got married and settled down in Cambridge by then. My then husband went into theological training in Cambridge, trained for the ministry… I left Cambridge when my husband was ordained, and went into his first job as a minister of the Church of England, which was in Bradford. He was on the staff of Bradford Cathedral, for his first post.

After about 18 months, I got rather fed up of travelling, and wondered what the options were, and saw a research post advertised, research assistant type post, advertised in the Department of Anthropology, in Cambridge… (pp.23-25)

At that stage, my husband was due for another move, because that was how it worked in the Church of England – three years, three years, and then a longer period. And we decided that he would follow me next time, and if I was able to get … He was, he was very instrumental in persuading me that having, by that stage, got a Ph.D., and got some teaching experience, it was not unreasonable to think that I might get a job in a university. I mean, I still didn't really have quite that confidence myself. And he said, "Go on, apply". And I said, "Oh, all right, I'll have a go. And I'll have a go at the next two or three things that come up, that I can vaguely apply for, if they're in places where we think we might like to move to". And the first one that came up was a post in Lancaster, where I applied for, and got. And he then … did whatever you do in the Church of England, to organise these things, and moved to a Parish in Preston. (pp.36-37)

We separated in 1979, and I left the …I left the marital home, because the marital home was a Vicarage, and bought a house of my own at that stage, yes. Yes. (p.58)

15. In to Anthropology

It was Esther who contacted me - and just offered me a position of a research assistant, working on Esther Goody's project of fostering children in West Africa. And so I went to Cambridge, Department of Anthropology, worked as a research assistant in the Centre for African Studies, and it was a wonderful experience. I mean, the work was a bit boring, actually, because I was analysing her data, if you like, and it was the early days of putting your data on to computer, so I would have to cycle down to the University computer, every morning, and find what print-outs we'd got overnight... But it was such a totally different experience of what being in a university means, when you're not a student, and of being in a university as part of a … set of research activities. I loved it. I got on very well with Esther. I went along to seminars, you know, and heard all sorts of really interesting people. … I learned, I think, I may have a slightly rosy view of this, but I think, from going to seminars in anthropology, in Cambridge at that time, I learnt, for the first time, what a real kind of scholarly community is like, if you like, which was for the very tough-minded intellectual debate…

I was very attracted to the anthropological method, and I think …probably it was more methodological than anything else.. I'd never been exposed to fieldwork methodology before, and I learned it's strengths. Perhaps I didn't learn too much about its weaknesses, but I certainly learnt its strengths there. I probably got a basic grounding in anthropological work on kinship as well. (pp.25-26)

16. Researching wives of the clergy

So I then was a full-time Ph.D. student at Bradford… and I had to decide what I was going to do...

I had to dream up a topic of some sort, and I can't really remember how I arrived at that, except that … I'm sure that Esther Goody had some influence on it... But, obviously, because of the particular situation that I was in, moving into, she was rather fascinated by

it, and I became rather fascinated by it, and it linked into my past interest in the sociology of marriage, and also into my growing awareness of second-wave Feminism…

PT: It sounds as if you weren't really a clergyman's wife, in the normal sense! (LAUGHS)

No. Well, yeah, I mean … it depends … The normal sense, perhaps, is not quite as normal as, you know, you might think, or even as I thought then. But I, certainly, was quite different from most of the people I was interviewing, that's perfectly true. And, I mean, I wasn't uninvolved, I was quite involved in … running Youth Groups and that sort of thing, and I certainly attended church and everything. I mean, I was a practising Christian, in a way, at that stage. … But I never - I knew, for sure, that I didn't want to make being married a career, if you see what I mean. I was absolutely certain of that. And so getting a Ph.D. was one way of not doing that! (pp.27-28)

17. Developing PhD questions

No, it wasn't. No, not at all. I don't think … In fact, I'm sure that I wasn't doing it as an autobiographical exercise, even a kind of pre-autobiography, as a sort of … research methodology. I was very clear that the reason why I was doing it was because I thought that there were interesting intellectual questions about the position of somebody who was, as I subsequently came to describe it, *Married to the Job*. And interesting intellectual questions, from a sociological perspective, and from a Feminist perspective.

And when I started it, … what I expected to find, and I suppose my research questions, at the beginning, were all geared to this, what I expected to find was that there would be quite clear tensions showing between a conventional expectation that clergy wives were part of the package that went along with the clergyman, and the desire of those same women to lead independent lives. We're talking, here, about the early seventies, when … that was the expectation. So I expected to be doing a piece of work which was exposing those tensions, and which, perhaps, demonstrated the dissatisfaction of women with that situation. In fact, a year or so into the research, when I'd got quite a lot of data already collected, I think … there was quite a sort of turning point when I realised that this was

not what I was finding, and that I … I had to understand what I was seeing, in a much more sociologically sophisticated way. And that took me quite a long time to work through, because there weren't really very many anchor points in sociology, at that time, that could help me…

PT: So what about the Feminism, was that through the Department?

There was … Sheila Allen was in the Department at Bradford, at that stage. Well, she stayed there, in fact, till she retired. And she was a very very positive influence … There was a group of women Ph.Ds., because they had a lot of Ph.D. students then. There was a group of women, a small group of women Ph.D. students, who she was very supportive of, on a personal basis, and she was very much an influence on thinking through Feminist ideas then, in the Department. I mean, that was, that was a very important strand to me…

18. Sampling and interviewing clergy wives

I saw an interview methodology as being the obvious thing to do, partly from the sort of anthropological experience in Cambridge, and partly because it was that kind of study that I'd been familiar with in my undergraduate years… And so I had a very carefully planned, it was a quite well-planned project, actually, carefully thought through selection procedures and that kind of thing…

I took the Anglican Diocese of Bradford, and interviewed people in four denominations, within the geographical boundaries encompassed by the Anglican Diocese. And so that was Anglican, Methodist, Baptist, and Congregationalist …Those [second] two, I think, subsequently merged, but they were separate at that stage. And so I defined it by geographical area. I then got, got the complete list of clergy, and sampled different fractions, according to the size of the churches, so that I ended up with not equal numbers, but numbers which would enable me to make comparisons. So that meant I sampled proportionately a lot more of the Anglicans than I did of the Non-Conformist denominations… And then I went off and interviewed them wherever they were. And, I mean, it was far too ambitious. I would never … Subsequently, when I started supervising research students myself, I was horrified at the scale that I'd been allowed to

… It was something like 150, which I conducted, transcribed them all myself, analysed them. Probably not terribly, you know, not as thoroughly as one would do now, but … I did everything myself. (pp.28-32)

19. *Married to the Job*: comparison in research

It really was several years before I got into my stride with research... A person who was very helpful to me, at that time, was John Wakeford, who was in the Sociology Department at Lancaster.. In the end, it was he who said, "Look here, I think that something like this is not broad enough to have the kind of appeal as an academic work". …" "So how could you broaden it?" "Could you think about making comparisons between what you've done, and what other people have done?" and so on.

It was out of that discussion that the idea of doing what turned out to be *Married to the Job* was born. I got quite excited by the thought of comparison. And then I began to think, something that has actually, I think, been characteristic of all my subsequent work, which is that the sort of comparisons between X, Y and Z, never should be just comparative between X, Y and Z, because "Gosh, isn't that interesting to compare X with Y and with Z", but because there is some underlying strand that links them, there is a research question there which links them, and of which each of them is an example. And you find out about the underlying issue by making these comparisons, but they're not comparisons for their own sake. And so, you know, the underlying research questions in *Married to the Job* are about whether there is something about the nature of marriage that takes particular forms in marriages where a man has a certain kind of occupation, and an occupation in which there is some kind of imperative, whether it be born of external expectations, or something inherent in the logic of the job, like, you know, a house goes with the job, or something like that, which draws women in, but that it's not necessarily that there's this category of jobs that women get involved in, and then the rest of the jobs that they don't. That there's something inherent in the nature of marriage that has this particular manifestation with those sort of jobs…

20. Contexts for developing research on gender

PT: And two of the circles you mentioned as being influential, in the book, one is a group at Lancaster, the Women's Research Group. Is it worth saying something about that?

Yeah. Yeah, I'm quite proud of having been in at the early stages of that, because Lancaster has developed some very good research on gender subsequently. Yes, … from probably about 1978 onwards, somewhere thereabouts, there were enough women in different Departments in Lancaster, to initially get together, just very informally, to meet, to talk, we just gave papers about our own research, read books and commented on them, had reading evenings, that sort of thing … very active little group, from about 1978 onwards. Subsequently that group spawned teaching programmes in Women's Studies, and got much bigger.

But the small Group, now, I probably can't remember everybody who was in it. But Sylvia Walby who came to the Sociology Department in 1978, from Essex, having been supervised by Mary McIntosh, and who was very much into Feminist theory, and Penny Summerfield, who is one of my closest friends still, who is a historian of the Second World War …

That, along with the BSA, which we'll talk about, was very much my intellectual home, at that stage, not the Department that I was working in, with one exception, which I'll come back to. (pp. 40-45)

21. Gender and caring

Roger Hadleigh… was quite in the vanguard of the then movement to focus on informal care, as opposed to formal, State provided care, as a much more acceptable method of providing support for … well, any category of people who can't look after themselves, but particularly we were all interested in older people. And he was very much involved politically, personally, academically, in all of that. And it was totally non-gendered. And it used to drive Dulcie and me up the wall, because he'd come in and talk, you know, at great length, and with enormous enthusiasm, because he was a man of very great enthusiasm, about all this. And we would say, "Well, haven't you noticed that it's women who do it all?" you know! "No, no, no, that's just incidental", etc. …

Subsequently, he actually became very sensitive to gender in his work. But at that stage, he wasn't.

And we actually got so annoyed with this, that we decided we were going to write something. And we were going to write a critique of his work, and others who were working in this mould … promoting the idea of informal care. It was subsequently published in the *Journal of Social Policy*, and it became one of the intellectual anchor points for a lot of other work that then developed on gender and caring. (pp.45-46)

22. BSA, women and gender

The BSA Sexual Divisions Study Group, BSA Women's Caucus, BSA Family Study Group, to some extent, but a slightly less extent, [are] all enormously important intellectual anchor points for me. These were the places at which I met, on a regular basis, people from round the country who were in a similar position to me, with similar interests to me. And, you know, we did meet much more regularly than, I think, the equivalents meet now … entirely at our own expense, and very cheaply. We would meet, for example, in Bradford, because Sheila was often involved in this. We would just meet entirely at our own expense, for a Saturday afternoon, and go off for a curry, and it was great! And the mixture, often a mixture, well, particularly the Sexual Divisions and the Women's Caucus, usually were only women attending, well, always only women attending Women's Caucus. And, you know, so it was often a mixture of intellectual work and plotting women's careers, and how to take over the BSA, and things like that!... I ended up chairing the BSA Executive at a very early stage in my career. Oh, '83-'84. '83-'84. I was on the Executive from 1980. It was Margaret Stacey that did that. She persuaded me to stand for the Executive. And I remember, almost can remember the words, actually! (pp.47-48)

23. Class and gender in preschool playgroups

I did a bit of part-time lecturing in FE as well. And in the FE College in Hull, they asked me to do a bit of extra work, which was a tailored programme for the Pre-Schools Play

Groups Association, training for staff … for volunteers, who were working with Play Groups… Therefore I got to know about the Pre-School Play Group Movement, which I hadn't known much about before, and got quite interested in it from, I suppose, a community development angle, and what role it had within all that.

That, somehow, got put together in my head with the interest that I was developing in Feminism and gender. And it, it emerged as a set of questions about the role, about the situations in which women were being used as volunteers, to run what was, essentially, might otherwise have been publicly funded services…

So it had a social policy angle, which was quite up-to-date, in that it was a volunteering, voluntary organisation, voluntary sector, running services which might otherwise be State services. But I got interested particularly in the social class angle, because … my experience of teaching people who were volunteers, on the programmes in Hull, had made me acutely conscious of the fact that … it was the kind of thing that middle-class women did – volunteer to run Play Groups. And, indeed, part of what we would now call "social capital" actually, the reproduction of social capital, in making sure that their children had other children of the same sort to play with, at an early age, and would then go on to meet the right sort of children at primary school, and so on. And I could see that all that was what normally happened in the Pre-School Play Groups, and the Organisation nationally, seemed to me, to very much reflect that kind of tone, if you like.

But I knew that they were trying to expand, and, indeed, I think, probably were able to get some funding from government to expand into the very deprived areas. But they were trying to expand in such a way that actually maintained this principle, that it was mothers who run the Play Group for their own children, if you like. And it seemed to me that there were some interesting intellectual questions there, about the way in which gender and social class map on to each other, in the context of something which had the kind of policy orientation that I wanted to develop.

So it was a very interesting small project. I selected … I think about six, maybe eight … no, six Pre-School Play Groups, that I identified on the basis that they had the characteristics that I was looking for, which was, essentially, the kind of areas that I was

looking for. I identified them through contacting Local Authorities mainly, because Local Authorities have to register Play Groups. And I did, I think I did 12 months observation, where I just went along, I went along and watched, and wrote field notes on what I saw. And at the end of the 12 months, I interviewed all the people running the Groups, and a selection of mothers who used them, who weren't involved in running them.

But, intellectually, I think probably the most, the most interesting work that I did, based on that, was about social deference, probably, and about the way in which working-class women, I suppose, in a sense, have a kind of double negative bit of their identity, and what that does to self-confidence, and what it does to the way in which they relate to other women. Plus, I think probably the best article I wrote on this, was actually given the title, "Dividing the Rough and the Respectable",

And, essentially, what you had was women running them, defining themselves as "respectable working-class", running organisations where they were dealing with the children of the "rough working-class".

I think I felt, quite strongly [critical], as a result of the work that I'd done on Play Groups, and wrote about in that article, that the … The public rhetoric of this was that it would be better … that there would be all sorts of gains, both for young children, and for their mothers, if they were put in these circumstances, rather than in a State-funded nursery school. Whereas, in reality, it's back to the argument about social capital, if you like. In reality, what children of the middle-classes got, in whatever circumstances they were in, in a self-help Play Group, yes, or in the nursery school, was the reproduction of social and cultural capital. And if middle-class mothers were running Play Groups for their own children, they were giving them that, whereas if you were asking mothers who, themselves, have got very little social capital, and very little educational background, for example, to run Play Groups for their own children, they are denying their children access to that sort of social and cultural capital. (pp.51-54)

24. Qualitative research in social policy

Education and Social Policy, I don't think. I mean that's a different sort of book altogether. By the time I started working on this,.. I was very much interested in methodology, and had adopted broadly qualitative methodology in all the research that I'd done to that date, and … was quite actively involved, I think, in national discussions about qualitative methods, and the development of qualitative methods at that time.

The subtitle was "Social and Educational Research", but all the illustrations were from education, all the substantive illustrations were from education, but the arguments were really about the use of qualitative methods in social policy research. And I don't really think many other people have taken it much further than that, I have to say.

Social Policy, as a discipline, Social Administration/Social Policy, as a discipline, has always been fairly unsophisticated about methods. Maybe that would be an unfair comment right now, but … certainly in the eighties, and more recently than that, too, you don't find lots of methodologists in Social Policy.

One was in the policy-making arena, the lack of legitimacy of qualitative methods, and the reliance, almost exclusively, on survey type methodology, and demographic analysis, and that kind of thing. And at the same time, a feeling that there was some legitimacy to the fact that qualitative research was not really regarded in the policy arena because, actually, it was often not very well done. It's very much a book of two halves. The first half is largely historical, and it's about the … the development of traditions of social policy research in Britain… I actually did work in the Mass Observation Archive. That's the only time I've ever done proper historical research. And the second half of it is more addressing "in principle" what could happen, if you like. And there, all the illustrations come from education. (pp. 57-59)

25. Women interviewing women

[I] did that article, probably at faster speed than most other things that I've ever done. But it turned out to be one of these things that's got recycled and quoted all over the place, and … I mean, I am… It had been misquoted to … a degree that makes it hardly recognisable to me.

It was quite important, in some ways, to my thinking about methodology, in that it was engaging with the debates about the ethics, the ethics of research, if you like, and particularly the ethics of the relationship between the researcher and research subject, which did influence the way in which I planned subsequent projects. And the point about the article, really, is that there is a gendered dimension to this, and that, in my experience in the clergymen's wives study, and in the play group study, … women with very different sorts of backgrounds, that I had, nonetheless, found that it was really quite easy to get them into an interview situation where they were revealing some quite private things, largely because one was tapping into some kind of learned, or natural sympathy between women.

It's been wildly misquoted to say that Janet Finch says that men can't interview women. And I don't think I quite said that! But … but that is not the point, actually. The point is something rather deeper than that, about … in a society which is quite divided on gender lines, in terms of people's experiences and their assumptions about who you can trust and that kind of thing, that it is a different sort of dynamic when you get a woman interviewing a woman, than when you get a man interviewing a woman.

PT: Do you think it's that the technique that a woman uses in interviewing should be any different?

No, I don't. But I think it means that women in those situations need to be highly sensitised to what it is they're doing, and aware that they are trading on something which is about gender, and not just about their skills as an interviewer. And, therefore, prepared to have moral positions, if you like, on how far you push people in the interview situation, and how you use the material that you've got, afterwards.

PT: So, basically, it's that women are more likely to reveal themselves to women, and, therefore, you have the extra ethical obligations?

Yes. Yes. I mean, not necessarily more likely to reveal themselves, but to reveal different aspects of their lives, or to more readily do that, on the presumption that a

woman interviewer will have an immediate inherent understand of what they're talking about. And it may be that sometimes that means actual facts about their lives get revealed that wouldn't get revealed to a man… It takes so little effort to get women to that stage, that there's a danger of lulling the interviewee into some kind of false sense that this is a confidence between women … The danger is that the interviewee then forgets what you told them at the beginning, that you're going to do something with this, you know? (pp.60-61)

26. Giving back to an interviewee

PT: I know Anne Oakley argues that you should give something back. Do you agree with that?

No, not really. I think it's quite difficult to do that. That was one of the things … that was one of the reasons why I wrote the article. I was quite influenced by that thought, at the time, and it's difficult … in a sense, it's difficult to argue against, in principle, or I found it difficult at the time, and yet it didn't feel quite right and I was struggling a little bit with it. I'm sure, in that article, I might not have reached a position on it, but I did subsequently. I think that … to say that you give something back, colludes with the idea that it isn't an interview.

I think that the moral position that I would adopt is that you must remember yourself, and you must keep reminding the interviewee that this is a research interview, and it's not the beginning of a friendship, it's not somebody who you might meet on a train, and never have to see again, so you can tell them anything you like. It's not a potential counselling situation. It is a research interview, with its own rules and boundaries, and that would be my position now. I'm not sure that I was as clear about it when I wrote that article. (pp.61-62)

27. Distress in an interview

PT: And what happens if they show themselves in acute distress?...

I would now, in conducting an interview about anything at all, actually, but certainly about family life, which is what I really do, I would stop if I see the signs of somebody becoming distressed, or being very anxious about the line of questioning. I don't think that it is right for, you know, the greater good, or something or other, of collecting research data, to press people on areas which they find sensitive or distressing. I think it's wrong. I think it's their right, as a citizen, even though they've agreed to be interviewed, it's their absolute right, as a citizen, not to find this a distressing experience.

And I think if one takes any other position than that, then you've got to prepared to work out, you know, how to pass them on to counsellors or whatever, and I just don't think that's the role of the researcher. (p.62)

28. Family Obligations and Social Change

That was obviously very much a defining moment in my career, because that was the point at which I, having doing quite a number of things in the previous ten years … I mean, it wasn't necessarily planned this way, but did, in fact, settle down to work on kinship, as what subsequently became the focus of all my work really…

I came to the topic of family obligations … the most direct route through which I came to that topic, was the work that I'd done with Dulcie Groves, on community care, because we had very complementary skills and backgrounds, if you like, in coming at that, and she had very much been brought up in the orthodox social administration tradition, and knew all about the legislation and that kind of thing. And we were both interested in gender. I brought to it the eye of the sociologist. And when we put those things together, I think it was quite powerful work that we were doing at that stage, and it was certainly very influential…

So I, increasingly, became interested in that, from the perspective of sociology of family relationships. And I had kept up an interest in family issues. I'd been an active member of the BSA Family Study Group, which was where I met David Morgan.

He was in my life at the time when I was planning the *Family Obligations* study. And although we've never, we've only ever done one piece of work together, and that was just one article, and he does very different sort of work on families than me, nonetheless, I think it, it probably was an influence in strengthening my interest in families as a topic, if you like, because his work was by far and away the best, and the most influential theoretical work on families that was around at that time.

So I was influenced from the theoretical angle, but also, the most direct route through which I came to it was the work that I'd done with Dulcie on community care. And something was forming in the back of my mind for two or three years, about kinship, and about what was being presumed in …all these policy initiatives about community care. What was being presumed about the nature of relationships between kin, and what people would, as it were, automatically want to do for each other. And that's really where the *Family Obligations* project came from. And I sat down and thought through, "I want to take this further", and rapidly realised that what I really wanted, would have to do, was quite a broad, and non-policy …not with a policy focus, but quite a broad sociological study of kinship, because, really, there was practically nothing then. There'd been nothing since the 1960s really…

So the way in which I did it was certainly not just to replicate any other previous study, but to approach the development of the research design, having in mind these questions about … what is it that can be expected of kin, what the people expect of themselves, and how does this fit in with the foundations of policies that seemed to be developing at that time? So although it was, by no means, an applied study, there were some pretty applied questions in the back of my mind, driving it…

The Family Obligations Study had two parts. It had a survey and a qualitative study. And I actually can remember, very vividly, the moment when I decided that that had to be. I originally assumed that it would be based on qualitative interviews…I was actually working on the survey at that stage, I think, and wrote the book. But *Family Obligations and Social Change* doesn't contain any of the data from the study. It was the, you know, it was the Chapter One, as it were! (LAUGHS) But it was, it was a major statement, I think, about the field. And it's a book that I'm very proud of. (pp.63-67)

29. Mixing qualitative and quantitative research

I can remember the moment when I realised, with something of horror, that, actually, the research questions that I was asking, could not be fully answered, unless I had some quantitative data with which to answer them, because some of them were the kind of thing that you're given the answer with quantitative data. You know, how frequent, how many … you know, how common, etc., are questions that you can only answer with quantitative data. And so, you know, with some anxiety that my friends would disown me, as it were, I planned a project which was a mixture of a survey and the qualitative interviews….

I thought my friends might disown me, yes, for doing a survey. But, anyway, there we are! And, in fact, my friends didn't disown me, I'm happy to say!

PT: And you were using both those methods at the same time? I mean, that would be unusual, at that point.

JF: Yes. Very unusual. I mean, I don't think I realised quite how innovative it was, until, you know, I was well into it, and I realised that I was doing something that other people were not doing. I mean, I took quite a long time planning it, and went to talk to a lot of different people about it. (p.66)

29. Conceptualising the interview

It was an open-ended qualitative type interview, but very carefully planned. … Jennifer and I worked together on the planning of it as well. She was quite involved in the intellectual work as well, at that stage. She wasn't involved in the survey at all, but she was involved at that stage. And we talked through what the content of the interview should be, in such a way that we were as confident as we could be that whichever of us did the interview, we would get comparable data out of it. And the interview schedule is driven partly, obviously, by the kind of descriptive data that we were looking for, about

people's families, about their experiences of giving help to kin, and receiving help from kin, but it's also an interview schedule in which there is a descriptive level, and then there is a conceptual level.

The questions that we asked were at the descriptive level, you know, as you would do with any interview of that sort. "Tell me about …" whatever. "Tell me a bit more about that", kind of questions. But the way in which we conducted our own thought processes in the interview, was intended to be, and I think, largely was successful, in being something which was driven by the underlying conceptual questions. Questions like "What type of reciprocity is being pursued here?" That sort of question, you know, so that we were trying, all the time, in the interview, to anticipate the analysis, and to get people to tell us things that would enable us to distinguish between different types of reciprocity, let's say. (p.68)

30. A theoretical sample from the survey interviews

PT: Okay. And, now, you were saying earlier, off the tape, that some of the interviewees were also in the survey?..

Yes. The two are connected in that way. The survey was all done in Greater Manchester... I think that we had 38 people who had been in the survey, out of a total of 120. And we selected those, because we had survey data on them, we selected them by characteristics which we thought might be particularly interesting for the qualitative study… It was theoretically driven. We were definitely using the concept of theoretical sampling, at that stage. So we were definitely not trying to do a sub-sample. We were trying to take ... in fact, we took some of the survey findings and thought about them, and then thought, who are the key groups that we need to get more qualitative data on, in order to understand the analysis that's emerging from the survey findings?

We began by selecting people in the following categories. One group were young adults, and the other group was people who had been divorced or separated. And the reason for that was that we thought that if we started with people in one or other of those groups, and we always had the intention of moving outwards to interview their kin, in some cases

… if we started with people in those two groups, we would probably be most likely to pick up instances where negotiations about, about obligations between kin, were going on. Negotiations or re-renegotiations. Because … that was an issue that had come out very clearly from the survey, and which, indeed, I'd got very interested in, on the basis of writing *Family Obligations and Social Change* – the negotiated nature of obligation. And by focusing, initially, on young adults, and on people who had been divorced or separated, we, we thought that we would pick up families in which the nature of the negotiation of relationships between kin would be nearer the surface… We ended up with 38 people who fell into one or other of those categories.

We were trying to, all the time, think about the underlying principles of theoretical sampling, and what it is that that means. So that, for example, … the principle of searching for negative instances is very important if you're being serious about theoretical sampling. … That the danger of the kind of methodology which we were using, was that, and I've seen other people do this, is that because you're not being driven by some kind of random sampling method, you get seduced into following up people who you think, "Oh, that sounds really interesting". And there are two dangers there. One is that you end up with sort of eccentric and exotic examples, if you like, only. But the more serious danger is that you can't explain why, there's no intellectual bite to an explanation of why you chose this person rather than somebody else. And how do you know whether, if you'd chosen somebody else, you would get something completely different? ..

What we were trying to do was to really think through, "On what grounds would you make a selection, if it's not random?" And issues like the need to search for, you know … So, okay, it's grounded theory methodology quite … largely, I think, so the need to think through, at each stage, what, so far, what is our working hypothesis at the moment, about negotiating family responsibilities? And if we are right, then what sort of people would confirm that we are right? But even more important, if we have got it wrong, what sort of people would show that we've got it wrong? And then you try to follow through the latter as well as the former, so that you're always … That sort of principle, I very firmly believe, gives you really a very robust basis for qualitative research, because you can say, "Oh, we did our best to disconfirm the hypothesis". I then put it in positivist language, and, "This is how it came out". So it's that kind of approach. (pp.69-71)

31. Interviewing family members

Well, the advantages were … I mean, it was absolutely essential to do something like that, given the underlying research questions of the Family Obligations Study. Because the study was all about obligations between kin, and to interview only one person and use them as an informant about obligations, patterns of obligation in which they're involved, even worse, in which other people in their families are involved, is bound to give you only one side of the picture. And I don't mean to say it's necessarily wrong, or distorted, or anything like that, that's an empirical question. But it clearly is one-sided. And, therefore, again, … you know, I think this was very innovative at the time as well, that when I designed the Family Obligation study originally, it was designed to have this feature built in, that there would be more than one side of the story, if you like… And we've got some instances which you can really only analyse and present as case studies, which are extremely rich, where we've got half a dozen members of the same family talking about the same set of circumstances, and how they all viewed it…

We interviewed everybody individually. Everybody was interviewed individually. They all knew that the other people were being interviewed... I mean, the way in which we did it, from an ethical point of view, as it were, is that we had, there was always somebody who was a starting point, and we asked that person's permission to approach their relatives. Well, first of all, we asked if they were willing to release the names of their kin. We asked their permission to approach them. We then approached them, we told them that their name had come from the particular individual, but that that person had made no commitment on their behalf, and that they had to make an independent decision about whether they were happy to be involved in this study. And, of course, some people said no, so we didn't always have complete kin groups. But we, for reasons that we've talked about, in relation to the ethics of research, we did not push people into saying yes. We gave them every opportunity to say no, if they wanted to…

The potential ethical problems I think we dealt with quite straightforwardly. I mean, we clearly didn't tell anybody what somebody else had said. We never did that. We said

that at the beginning to everybody, "We're not going to pass on what you've said, to any of your relatives".

PT: And so also you couldn't then, for instance, publish a case study of a family which was identifiable in any way…

It's not likely, having used pseudonyms, that people would recognise themselves. But we did, in one instance.. because of the sensitivity of the circumstances, it was a case study about the care of an elderly father, ..where we had data from four or five siblings about it, and there was quite a lot in there about problems in relationships between the parents, and between the parents and the children, that we, in writing that up, we did actually, we further changed, we gave alternative pseudonyms, and we also changed some of the details. I think we changed the gender of some of the siblings or … I can't remember exactly what we did, but we made changes so that it couldn't be recognised. But, by and large, it wasn't too much of a problem to do that.

In *Negotiating Family Responsibilities*, which is the book that utilises this data, we rely quite a lot on case study presentation to do that, because although … we use a mixture, we use a mixture of aggregated experiences and case studies, but I think that most of the detail comes in the case studies. … They're mostly defined conceptually, rather than descriptively. (pp.71-74)

32. The survey and vignettes

The purpose of the survey was not to find, not … I did collect a small, a relatively small amount of data on people's experiences of being involved in mutual aid of one sort or another, with their kin. But that was not the main point of the survey. The main point of the survey was to, it was what would be called, in survey parlance, an attitudinal survey. It was about beliefs and values.. those underlying issues concerning obligations within families. However, partly because I am, basically, a qualitative researcher, … I was very dissatisfied with the type of questions which I saw being used in other surveys, which tried to get at beliefs and values, which were either far too direct, you know, "Do you think that somebody should … do X, Y or Z?" Or were … too crudely hypothetical, if

you like – "What would you do if …?" And the sociologist in me said, "If you ask either of those questions, you don't … what is it that you get if you ask either of those questions?" And I don't think that you necessarily get what you're looking for, if what you're looking for is some kind of underlying structure values which might, really, bear a relationship to what people do in their own lives.

So I had some very interesting discussions with SCPR about what I wanted to do, and I think they had some reservations about it. But the major, the most important parts of the survey were built round vignettes, which is where the article about vignettes comes in. They were scenarios, you might call them, which I wrote, and I wrote them in a way which was very closely related to the research questions that I was trying to understand. ..So instead of saying, "What would you do, Paul, if one of your children came to you and said, you know, 'I've made a stupid investment and I've lost all my money, and they're going to reclaim my house, and … help!'…Yes! Exactly, yes! `Help!'" you know. "What would you do, Paul?"

Instead of asking you that, the question would come in the form, "Joe Bloggs is in his fifties, with three grown up children, and, you know, still paying off his mortgage, or whatever. One day, one of the three comes to him and says this. What should Joe Bloggs do in these circumstances?" (pp.74-75)

33. Inheritance, property and family relationships

In our in-depth interviews for Family Obligations, we questioned, to a limited extent, on inheritance, and we got some data on that. But we hadn't made it a particular focus. But in the course of doing the analysis of the Family Obligations work, we became very interested in inheritance…. Our focus on Family Obligations had been very much … the kin groups of people who, themselves, were in young, young adult life, or mid adult life. And … tracking the way in which … obligations and responsibilities were negotiated in the young adult life scale, by and large. But we recognised that this continues, and realised that if you actually had put the focus on the end of life, you know, if we'd have, instead, chosen to start with elderly people, and do their kin group, then we probably would have found … well … or would we? Question mark. Have found that there is a

further part of this story, which is about how the potential for inheritance, to get drawn back into the negotiations of … other sorts of obligations, and to affect the way in which other obligations get negotiated, particularly around elderly people. Questions like, "Does the fact that somebody expects to be left something by a parent or an uncle or something, mean that they feel a different sort of responsibility to support them in old age, than others do if they don't think they're going to get left some …?" That kind of thing.

Although we had asked quite a lot of questions about financial support, within the Family Obligations Study, in essence the Family Obligations Study was not about the material aspects of family life, if you like. And I recognised, as a sociologist, that many sociologists would think this is a huge omission, and that, you know, economic relationships, within the household, certainly, had been the core of what recent sociology of the family had been about, and that we hadn't really looked at materiality at all. And so the question of the economic relationships between kin was something that we could look at, by utilising inheritance in that way. So it was a very nice follow-on, but it was planned to be a study which wasn't, wasn't sort of Part II of Family Obligations, but definitely built on what we had learnt about English kinship. So it was, it was a study of kinship as much as inheritance. And the book that we have produced most recently, published in 2000, *Passing On*, which is the final thing that I think we will write from the Inheritance study, is actually a book that is about kinship. (pp.79-80)

34. Decline of the wider family?

The then common wisdom about contemporary families, which I am distressed to say, is probably, to some extent, still the common wisdom, so really, in that sense, I failed to make an impact on it, was the story with which we are all too familiar, that industrialisation in the 19th and 20th centuries has … destroyed the strength, the previous strengths that were there of the wider kin group, and has produced families which, in essence, are coterminous with households, and that the wider kin relationships are unimportant. And in a sense, our family lives are relatively impoverished as a consequence of all these changes. A view which the Bethnal Green studies were partly responsible for promulgating, in my opinion.

And it was partly, partly my own experience of my own family, not just in the past, but in the present, which gave me the confidence to recognise what I really knew from other sources, that this was wrong, that this could not be true…. The importance of my work since the mid-eighties, on the topic of kinship, is that I think I've produced the basis for showing, very clearly, that … that kin relationships remain extremely important in the contemporary world, and that, of course, as social and economic circumstances change, the form which they take changes...

If you ask questions of your friends, you'd find that I wasn't unusual, you know, in… feeling that relationships across generations, three or four generations, remained important to me at some level, in practical as well as emotional terms, and that lateral relationships also, to some extent, were important. And this was true of anybody I asked the question casually of…

35. Families, wills and inheritance

Well, there were three parts to that study. We were trying to … find out a range of different sorts of things, but all around the sort of core questions of how do families utilise inheritance, as part of … the ongoing relationship of the family, if you like? How do they manage the process of transmission? How does that relate to the other kind of obligations and responsibilities that they feel to each other?

We didn't attempt to do anything on the wealthy, for whom inheritance would have been an issue for a number of generations. We were interested in trying to understand how people, who were relatively new to the experience of inheritance, were handling it, and what that told you about the family relationship. And so those were the core questions, and they were reflected in the research design. And we had three elements to it.

The first element, chronologically, was a study of wills... And rejected, at quite an early stage, the idea of doing a survey on this. You couldn't have got at this with survey methods at all.

PT: People wouldn't say?

No, well I know, from the in-depth interviews, how difficult it is for people to remember what they have received, let alone to tell you what their own bequeathing intentions are …

So we actually went for hard data on what people had actually done when they wrote a will. And we did that through a sample of 800 wills of people who had died, and when they've been through probate they're public documents. So, so we sampled it through the Public Records Office. And we, we did it over a 40 year period. We had four sample years, beginning with 1959...

The in-depth interviews were not connected, there wasn't an actual connection in terms of individuals, between them and the wills study, that was selected on a completely different basis..

We had a third part to this study which was really an exploratory, pilot type study, where we interviewed some solicitors. I think it was about 25 or 30, in the end. It was never intended to be more than a shot in the dark, but it was important to have a go at it, because … we were trying to find out what … patterns of bequeathing, and their bequeathing intentions, would tell us about their understanding of kinship. ...

So if I come to the in-depth interviews, we … adopted a rather similar methodology there to the in-depth interviews in the Family Obligations Study, namely, we started with individuals, and then with some, but not all of them, worked outwards and interviewed kin… In fact, it was a version of quota sampling.

We wanted some people in the sort of young adult age group, and we used the Electoral Registers to pick up … new electors are identified as new electors on Electoral Registers... We wanted to go to the other end of the spectrum, we wanted some kin groups where we started with an older person, so we, we got access to a number of residential Homes where we interviewed people... But we did it on a quota basis, that we knew we wanted to compose it this way. And we used the same kind of approach for deciding whose kin group to follow through…

We were actually positively seeking out people who'd had experience of divorce and remarriage in their families … Not just because it was inherently interesting, though it is very inherently interesting from an inheritance perspective, and lawyers get very excited about that! Oh yes! But … because … we believed that, the same sort of logic as *Family Obligations*, we believed that if you select people who have some experience of those circumstances, … they will be more likely to be able to talk to you about the kind of negotiations that go on about inheritance, in those circumstances, and this will tell you about how they perceive the nature of the different kin relationships that they have. So ... it's a vehicle through which you enable people to bring out of their heads, what you want to know, if you like. (pp.81-86).

36. A role model for younger women?

Well, from that point of view it's a very lonely position. It's a fairly lonely position anyway, actually. I am deeply frustrated about the lack of movement in the number of women Vice-Chancellors that we have…

That means that I'm very, very conscious, it is an extra pressure on me, without any doubt, that anything that I do, any mistakes that I make, and everybody makes mistakes, you try to minimise the number that you make, but you can't pretend that you don't make any. Any mistake that I make is, potentially, going to be seen as something that has gone wrong *because* I'm a woman. "That's what you expect from a woman." ..

Oh, I think I feel a huge responsibility to [be a role model for younger women], yes. Not particularly self-consciously, I think. I've always enjoyed encouraging younger people's careers, and it comes very naturally. And I … I'm happy to play that role directly, wherever I can. It is, of course it's a very common experience for women, in any leadership position, that you have very high expectations when you're appointed, other women have high expectations, that you will be able to change things. And, of course, that almost always ends up in disappointment, because you never can change things as quickly as they would like, and that you might like yourself. (p.100)